

Leading Faculty in an AI Era

Gaining Traction with Stability,
Exposure, and Empathy



By Jeffrey Selingo

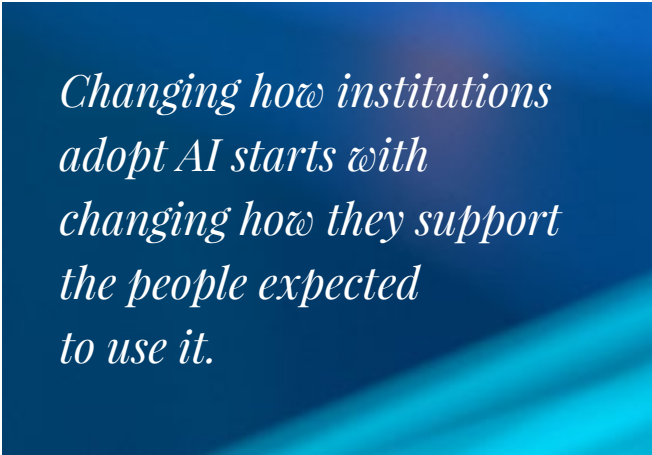
INTRODUCTION

Across colleges and universities, generative AI has rapidly gone from novelty to flash point. In the span of just three years, the technology has raised existential questions about the value that faculty members bring to what have always been deeply human endeavors: teaching and research.

Technology has long reshaped the role of the professoriate, of course. With the shift from the analog blackboard to the handheld calculator to, eventually, the personal computer, the internet, and the learning management system, each new innovation expanded access to information and chipped away at the “sage on the stage” model. But those changes unfolded over years, sometimes decades. Even the internet, which enabled online learning at scale, moved more slowly than generative AI.

Faculty recognize the AI disruption, whether or not they’re true believers in its promises. In a recent survey by the American Association of Colleges and Universities (AAC&U) and Elon University, nearly eight in 10 said the typical teaching model in their department will be affected by generative AI, and 86 percent believe it will alter the work and the role of those who teach.¹

What makes this moment distinctive is not just the speed of this life-altering technology but the unease it creates. Barriers to adoption are often cultural and psychological rather than technical. AI is challenging many faculty members’ sense of expertise, autonomy, and connection to their work and profession. When such needs feel threatened, resistance follows. Research on the workplace shows that in the absence of psychological safety, people become more likely to disengage or to push back in quiet opposition and less willing to experiment or collaborate.²



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Changing how institutions adopt AI, then, starts with changing how they support the people expected to use it.

This is where many institutions are getting stuck. They are treating AI as a policy to write or a technology to deploy, when it is fundamentally a people problem to solve.

On many campuses, AI is already producing competing visions of the professoriate of tomorrow. In one, AI elevates teaching, learning, and research. In another, it erodes trust, authenticity, and the core relationships at the heart of learning. The question is not whether institutions will change, but which version of the future they’ll create.

“There’s a recognition in higher ed that AI is more profound than the first generation of the internet, that it will change everything from how we do research, how our business processes work, how we teach, and how we learn,” said Ann

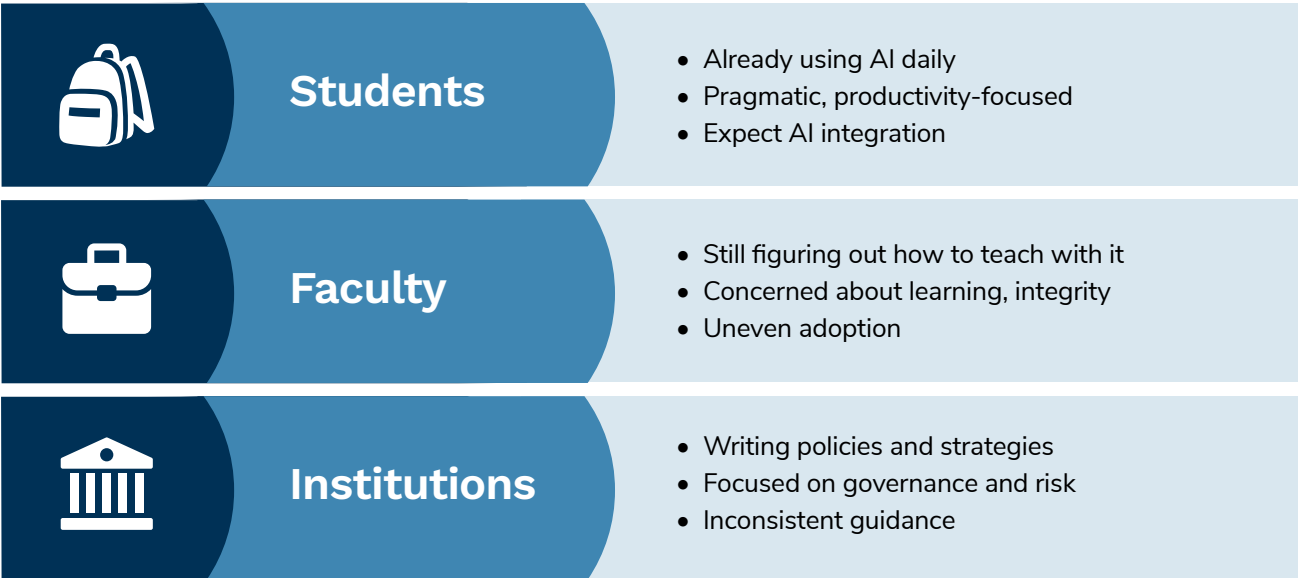
Kirschner, a senior advisor to the president at the University of California and university professor at the City University of New York, who has a long history in technology development. “To me, what it means to be educated in this era is about how well you can deploy these new tools without losing the friction of the struggle that sometimes comes with learning.”

Even as institutions develop their AI strategies and policies, and as students incorporate AI into how they learn, faculty are working out what it means for how they teach. At the same time, institutions are also facing financial constraints, political pressures, declining enrollments, and rising expectations for outcomes, only adding to the strain on faculty. That makes this moment even more difficult to navigate, because the debate over AI is unfolding at a time of heightened uncertainty in higher education.

This report attempts to inform the discussion by drawing on decades of research about leadership and psychological safety. Based on interviews with some two dozen faculty members and two roundtable dinner discussions I hosted for administrators in the fall of 2025—one for academic leaders and another for chief technology officers—it outlines the steep cultural hurdles to AI adoption in higher education and lays out a framework for creating the conditions for lasting change.

FIGURE 1

Where AI Adoption Breaks Down on Campus





Solving for Culture, Not Technology

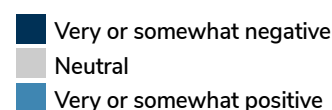
For faculty, generative AI is not simply a tool to learn and use. It is a direct challenge to the expertise they have spent their careers building: the ability to synthesize, interpret, and generate knowledge in ways that once set them apart from their students. Even faculty who are curious about AI often find themselves in an uncomfortable position when they're expected to teach with a technology they're still learning. Their students sometimes arrive knowing more about it than they do. That asymmetry is new, and it is quietly reshaping the dynamics of the classroom more than any policy.

"One of the existential threats that I see is the fact that our students are coming in AI ready and our faculty are not," Pranesh Aswath, provost and executive vice president for academic affairs at Texas State University, told me during one of our roundtables. "And that, to me, is a fundamental problem, because students have a level of expectation at a university that we're not able to deliver."

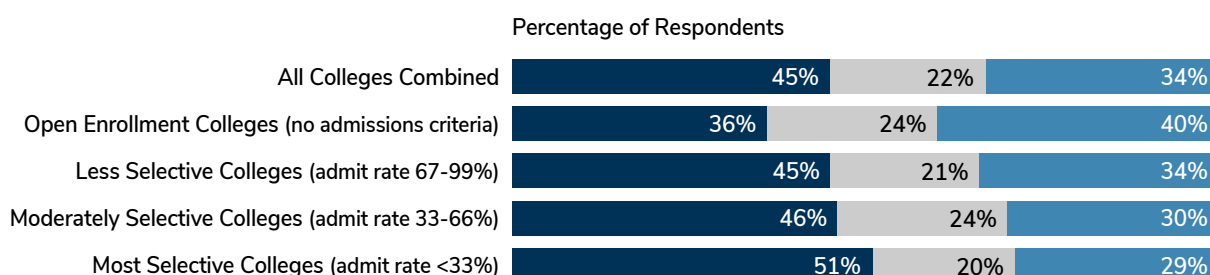
Across higher education, professors not only believe AI will disrupt the traditional teaching model but also are poised to resist in large numbers. A College Board survey of more than 3,000 faculty members found a plurality with a negative overall sentiment about generative AI use in higher education.³ The negativity was particularly pronounced at elite, selective institutions and in disciplines such as the humanities and social sciences, compared with fields like business and STEM (*see Figure 2*).

FIGURE 2

Faculty Sentiment About Use of AI in Higher Education

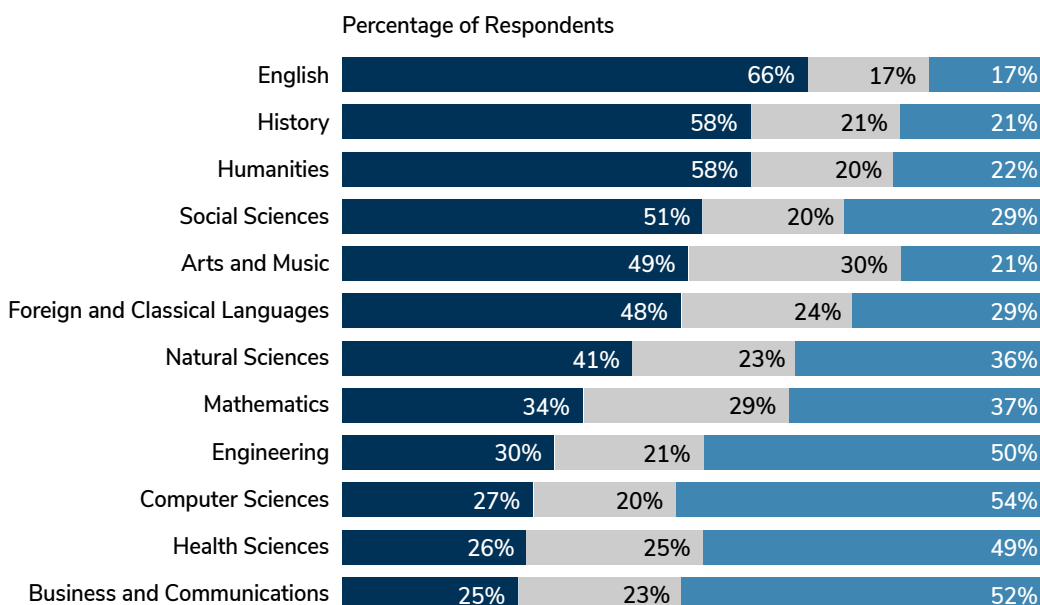


Higher education isn't a monolith, and neither is how colleges think about AI. Faculty members at institutions with higher acceptance rates have more positive feelings toward AI than those who teach at the most selective campuses...



Note: The chart above shows responses to the following question:
"What is your overall sentiment about the use of AI in higher education?"
Number of respondents = 3,274.

...and those positive feelings are also more pronounced in certain disciplines, such as business and STEM, compared with the humanities and social sciences.



Note: This chart shows responses to the same question, by faculty discipline.
Number of respondents = 3,132.

Source: College Board, "College Faculty Perceptions of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education," February 2026.

How can college leaders develop policies for a faculty uneasy with the technology? The key is to reduce uncertainty so professors feel confident embracing, exploring, and applying new tools and approaches, while keeping the human connection at the center of teaching.

“The best learning that happens at most institutions is in groups where you can build real, meaningful relationships,” said Paul Cherukuri, a professor of entrepreneurship and the chief innovation officer at the University of Virginia. “AI can complement those connections by helping people think through their ideas first—whether it’s a faculty member preparing to engage a colleague or a student who might be intimidated approaching a professor.”

The value of connection extends beyond the classroom. Leaders who help people feel capable, in control, and connected are more likely to build teams that adapt, learn, and remain engaged, according to Jamil Zaki, a professor of psychology at Stanford University and director of the Stanford Social Neuroscience Lab. “Many workers, deeply concerned about how the technology will change their jobs, are experiencing rising levels of mistrust,” Zaki wrote in a widely shared *Harvard Business Review* article.⁴

Taken together, these dynamics suggest that many institutions are approaching AI from the wrong starting point. The issue is not simply what policies to write, but what conditions to create to enable the trust needed to integrate AI on campuses.

Three Conditions Enable AI Strategies to Gain Traction



Stability

Reduce
uncertainty



Exposure

Build
experience



Empathy

Address identity
and trust

Stability. Faculty are being asked to adapt to AI in a moment that already feels unsettled. So people are less willing to experiment—not because they intentionally resist, but because they lack a stable foundation from which to take risks. Research shows that when workers feel their roles or institutions are uncertain, they are more likely to disengage or retreat from new initiatives.⁵ “We’re designed to resist change. We’re really good at that,” a provost at a public research university said during one of our roundtables. “How many of *our* structures and processes are getting in the way of adapting?”

Where to start: Set time-bound expectations for how the technology will be integrated. Defining what faculty are expected to do now, what can wait, and what is still being explored helps position AI as a bounded initiative rather than another source of ongoing disruption.

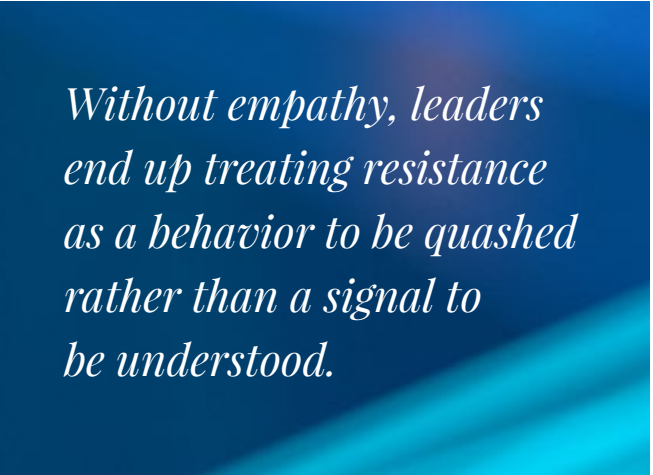
Exposure. Stability alone is not enough. In many cases, faculty don't understand what they're being asked to do, and so they respond to AI in ways that leaders often don't anticipate. The same survey from the College Board that shows skepticism among faculty also shows that it's highest among those with the least direct experience using the technology. Without hands-on exposure, people are more likely to understand AI as an abstract threat than as a practical tool. More broadly, research on workplace adoption finds that employees are far less enthusiastic about AI than leaders assume, in part because they lack clarity on how it will affect their work.⁶

Where to start: Create structured, low-stakes opportunities for faculty to engage with AI, through workshops, "sandbox" environments, or peer-led demonstrations, so that awareness is built through experience rather than assumption (see sidebar on American University).

Empathy. Even institutions that provide stability and exposure can fail to bring faculty on board if they misread what the resistance is actually about. It's rarely about the technology itself. AI is changing how people view their competence, autonomy, and sense of belonging. Pushback that looks like obstruction is often something closer to grief. A CIO at a private university said during one of our roundtables that she walked over to the computer science department one day because she was told they "hated" central IT. "I said to them, 'You're not going to believe me. Nobody in central IT wakes up trying to find ways to slow you down.' And they laughed," she said. "So I told them that I'm going to keep trying to demonstrate with experiences, with change, with consistency, with actions, and with data that it's true."

Without empathy, leaders end up treating resistance as a behavior to be quashed rather than a signal to be understood. In practice, that leads to weaker adoption.

When AI is rolled out in the absence of empathy or trust, research on the workplace shows, employees simply produce busy work (workslop) or actively oppose adoption by sabotaging their organization's AI strategies.⁷ "When placed in a zero-sum environment with a new technology, people will naturally protect themselves," Zaki wrote. Leaders who ignore that dynamic risk slowing the very change they are trying to accelerate.



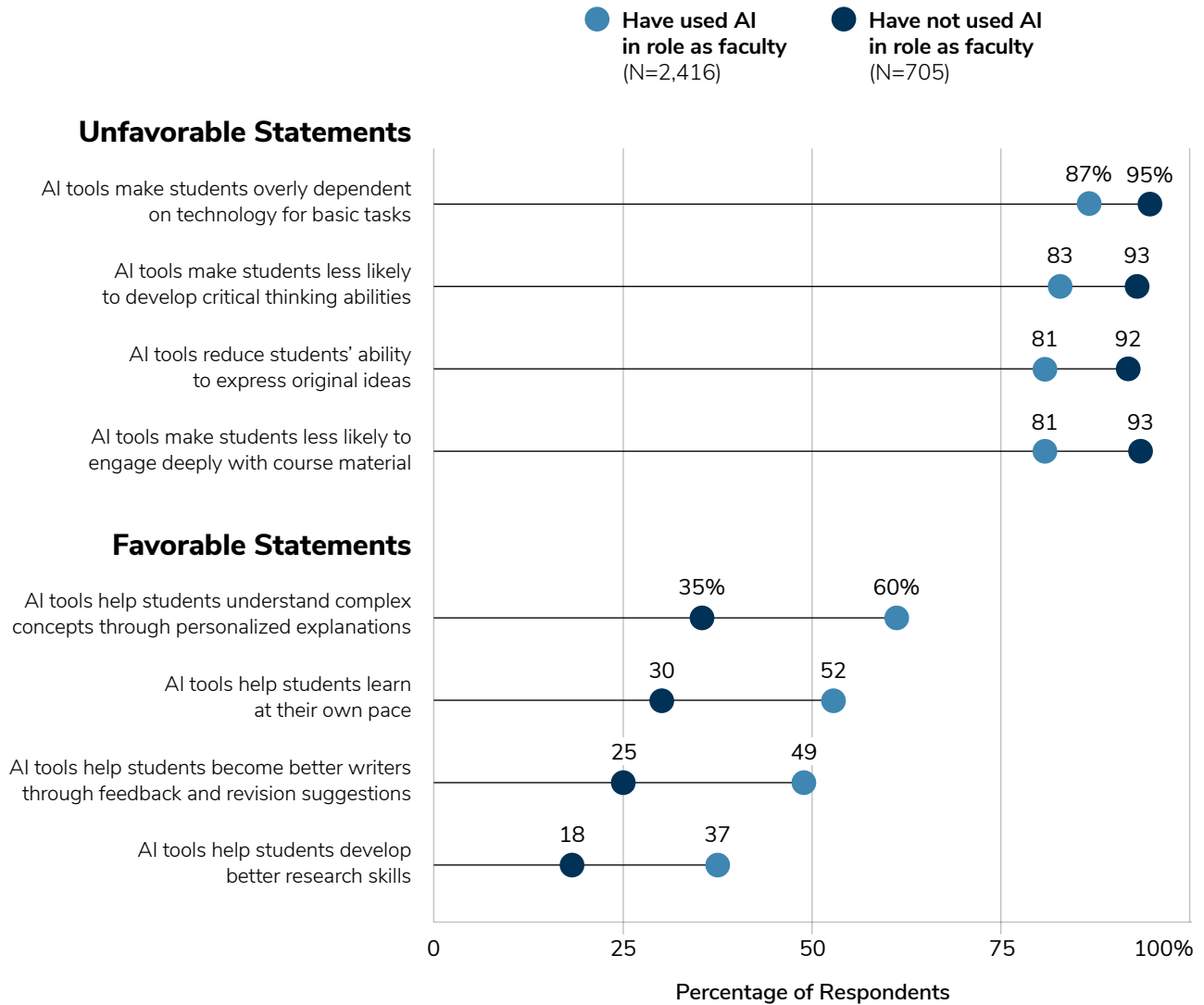
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Where to start: Involve faculty directly in shaping AI strategy. Rather than announcing policies, leaders can co-create them through structured conversations that surface concerns, clarify tradeoffs, and give faculty a say in how AI is integrated into their work. Duke University, for example, convened a university-wide steering committee on artificial intelligence that brought together faculty, administrators, and other stakeholders to develop recommendations for how AI should be used in teaching, research, and operations.⁸ That approach shifts AI from something done *to* faculty to something developed *with* them.

FIGURE 3

The Divide Between Faculty Who Use AI Tools and Those Who Don't

Agreement with statements, by faculty AI use



Note: Participants responded to the following prompt: "Please indicate your level of agreement with each statement about generative AI." They could select "completely agree," "somewhat agree," "somewhat disagree," or "completely disagree." The above figure combines "completely" and "somewhat" responses to illustrate basic level of agreement.

Source: College Board, "College Faculty Perceptions of Generative Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education," February 2026.

How Faculty at American University's Business School Infused AI Throughout the Curriculum

In 2023, when venture capitalist Brett Wilson spoke at American University's Kogod School of Business, a student asked if AI would replace them. Wilson's answer—AI won't replace you, but someone who knows AI might—was a common statement back then. For Kogod's dean, David Marchick, it was a call to action.

Rather than convening a two-year task force to sort out an approach, he gave a committee six weeks and a five-page limit on a plan. Their recommendation: infuse AI into everything. "I don't think we really had a perfect plan," Marchick admitted. "We wanted something that would allow us to figure things out as we went."

The timing felt right. The school was in the middle of a curriculum revamp that would reimagine the student experience. Casey Evans, Kogod's associate dean for undergraduate programs and student services, said, "We had this perfect storm where before AI was even a thing, we were talking about making big changes here."

Early resistance: But even in a faculty primed for change, culture proved stubborn. For many, the first instinct was to wait it out. "I felt like, 'We've been through this before,'" said Tommy White, director of Kogod's Veloric Center for Entrepreneurship. "We had the internet, e-commerce, and this is just one of those things," he'd thought. "I'm probably going to retire before it really takes off."

What changed the dynamic at Kogod was giving faculty a low-stakes place to experiment. Angela Virtu, now associate director of the school's Institute for Applied Artificial Intelligence, helped design monthly gatherings called AI Second Fridays. "It was really a space where we could take the ego away,"



"I don't think we really had a perfect plan. We wanted something that would allow us to figure things out as we went."



David Marchick
Dean, Kogod School
of Business,
American University

Virtu said. “You could say, ‘I tried this and it was horrible,’ or ‘None of my students liked it.’ We could all be okay with failing as we tried this new thing together.”

For White, what made the difference was putting in 60 to 80 hours of related coursework, videos, and experimentation over a summer. By doing the “homework,” he said, “you’re going to figure out how to apply this to your class, versus just saying no, this won’t work.” White eventually reinvented his entrepreneurship course around AI-enabled rapid prototyping.

The tipping point: By the summer of 2025, more than 80 percent of the school’s faculty had adopted AI in their courses. At that point, Kogod’s leaders started to check in with those who hadn’t done so, to ask what they were thinking for fall. “There was a tipping point,” Marchick said, “where everyone felt that this was moving and they didn’t want to be left behind.” By fall, more than 90 percent of faculty were actively using AI in their courses.

AI adoption at Kogod is already helping its students in job interviews, said Christina Eid, a senior marketing major who conducted a survey of undergraduates. The share of Kogod students being asked about their AI skills by potential employers jumped from 12 percent in 2024 to 42 percent in 2026. Employers “want to know what your overall skills are,” Eid said, “and if you are able to talk about it in a way many aren’t.”

The uptake: The transformation at Kogod has been sweeping. In less than three years, artificial intelligence has been woven into every course. The school offers more than 142 AI-related electives, has hired six new AI and machine-learning faculty, and has launched the Institute for Applied Artificial Intelligence to coordinate research and cross-campus collaboration. Freshman enrollment has climbed 39 percent since the initiative began, and the school has raised \$41 million in that same period, compared with \$8.5 million in the five years prior.

Yet Marchick is candid about what remains unsolved. “We’ve figured out how to infuse it,” he said. “We don’t really know how to assess it.” That work—measuring whether AI integration is improving learning outcomes—is the focus of a new research partnership Kogod officials hope to launch with other business schools later in 2026.

Clearing the Cultural Barriers

If the barriers to AI adoption are cultural rather than technical, then progress depends less on new policies than on new behaviors. Institutions cannot mandate their way to genuine adoption, nor can they rely on scattered pilots or one-time training sessions. What they need instead are a set of repeatable moves that align institutional strategy with how faculty really work.

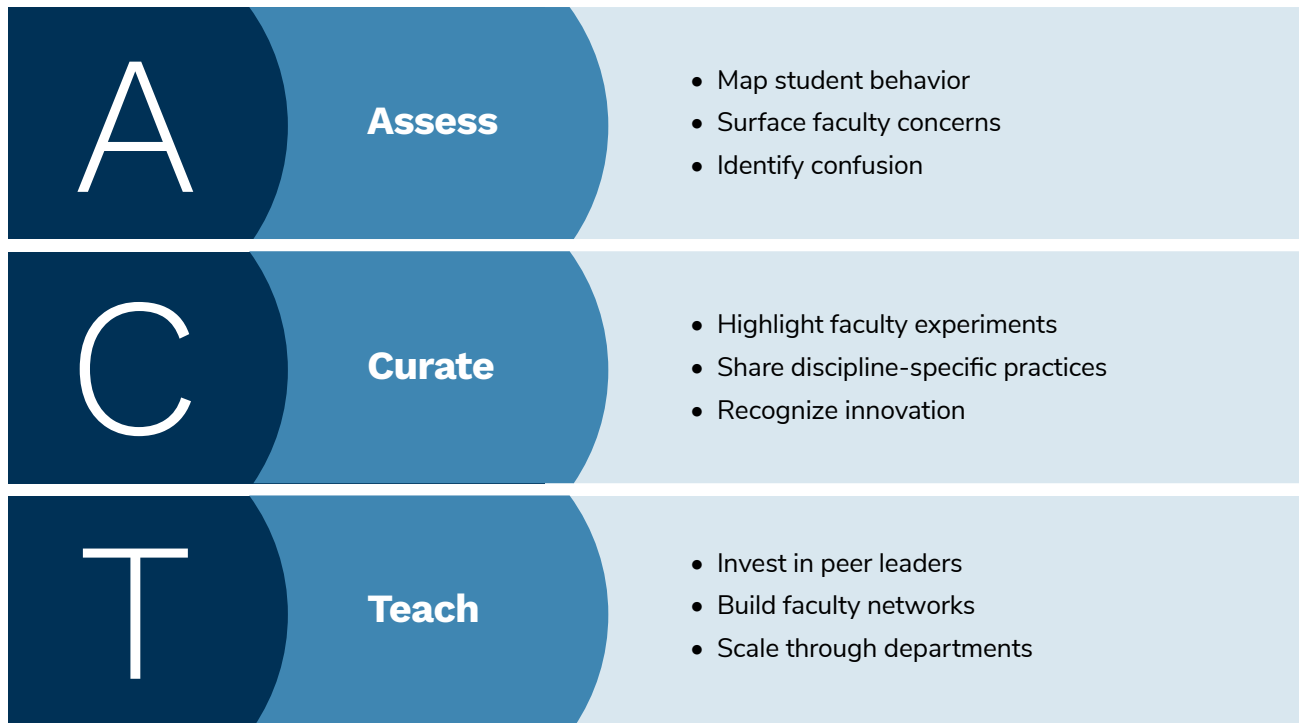
They can apply what I call the **ACT** framework:

- **Assess** your own reality
- **Curate** and amplify what's working
- **Teach** the people who shape practice

Together, these moves can determine whether AI strategies take hold.

FIGURE 4

A Framework for Cultural Change in AI Adoption



Assess Your Own Reality

The first move is to understand what is really happening on campus. Too often, institutions begin with policies or aspirational strategies that bear little resemblance to day-to-day experience. Students are already using AI extensively, often in ways that are invisible to instructors. Faculty, meanwhile, are experimenting unevenly, with many still unsure how to guide or respond to that use.

Assessing reality means mapping **the real landscape**—how students are using AI, how faculty perceive it, and where confusion is greatest—before creating official guidelines. It also means recognizing that there is no single campus-wide experience. AI use varies widely by discipline, course design, and instructor tenure.

“We welcomed a new cohort of tenure-track faculty, and a lot of them were really eager about AI, asking, ‘Where do I get to play in the sandbox?’” said a provost from a public research university at one of our roundtables. “But these are the least safe faculty on our campus. It’s not fair to tell them to experiment when their senior colleagues may penalize them.”

To better understand the AI landscape on its 22 campuses, the California State University system conducted a survey and gathered responses from more than 94,000 students, faculty, and staff—the largest effort of its kind in higher education.⁹ The findings revealed not just widespread AI use, but **sharply different experiences across groups**: staff reported the most positive impact, students were largely optimistic, and faculty were the only group evenly split, reporting both positive and negative effects. Just as important, roughly seven in 10 faculty said they want formal AI training.¹⁰ That combination of demand and ambivalence is exactly the kind of information leaders need to understand before writing policy.

Resistance is not always an obstacle, but it is a signal to be interpreted. It identifies where expectations are unclear, where support is lacking, and where cultural norms are in flux. Institutions that skip this step risk building strategies on assumptions rather than reality.

Curate and Amplify What’s Working

Once institutions map faculty adoption, they often find that many professors are experimenting with new approaches that integrate AI in productive ways, even if those efforts remain siloed within departments.

The problem is that these experiments are not systematically documented, shared, or replicated. As a result, leaders underestimate how much progress is underway, and faculty miss opportunities to learn from it.

So, curate what’s working. Identify **concrete examples** to share with faculty: assignments that encourage thoughtful AI use,



classroom practices that surface its limitations, and course designs that emphasize skills AI cannot easily replicate. The examples you find may reflect different disciplines' pedagogical traditions and learning goals.

Curation involves recognition, as well. In academia as in business, what gets attention often shapes what gets adopted. Faculty pay close attention to what's rewarded with tenure and promotion, but they also respond to more **immediate signals of value**: whose work is highlighted, whose innovations are taken seriously, and who is seen as leading. When institutions celebrate effective uses of AI, they indicate that this work matters.

For instance, the collection of AI faculty use cases at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte brings together more than 80 first-person accounts from a variety of disciplines. These narratives trace the journey from skepticism to practical use, highlighting the moments when AI began to meaningfully enhance teaching and learning.¹¹



Over time, such efforts can broadly change behaviors and even shape formal incentive structures. What begins as recognition then becomes expectation.

Take Arizona State University's challenge grant program, which has generated hundreds of faculty proposals for AI-enabled teaching and research. Rather than dictating use cases from the center, ASU invited faculty to define where artificial intelligence could have the most impact, then backed those ideas with technical support and access to multiple AI models. The result is not a single initiative, but a pipeline of **faculty-driven experimentation**, with institutional resources helping move ideas from concept to practice.¹²

Across colleges and universities, innovation is already happening, but it is fragmented and often invisible. Institutions that systematically identify and support these efforts make it easier for others to follow, turning siloed experiments into collective progress. But surfacing what works is only part of the challenge. The harder question is how to move promising practices beyond the faculty who originated them, and that depends less on information than on the people trusted to carry it.

Teach the People Who Shape Practice

The final move is to expand what's working by investing in the people who influence how teaching actually happens. Even when institutions understand the landscape and identify effective practices, they often struggle to progress beyond early adopters. This is where internal capacity becomes essential.

Traditional professional development models—centralized workshops or one-time sessions—are not sufficient. AI is evolving too quickly, and its applications are too context-dependent, for those relatively static approaches to keep pace. Instead, institutions need to invest in ongoing, peer-based learning.

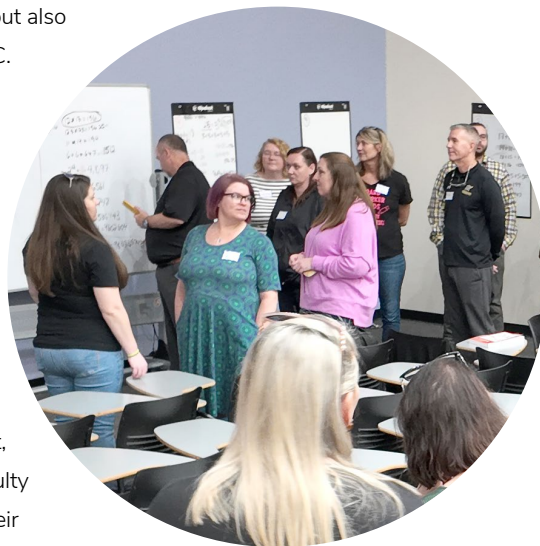
That means focusing on the “middle layer” of the organization: department chairs, program directors, and experienced faculty who

serve as **informal leaders** within their units. These individuals translate institutional priorities into disciplinary practice.

“What you’re looking for is someone who is comfortable trying new things, but also possesses opinion leadership on campus, someone people will follow,” said C. Edward Watson, vice president for digital innovation at the American Association of Colleges and Universities and co-author of the book *Teaching with AI: A Practical Guide to a New Era of Human Learning*. “Who just won the teaching award? Who just rotated off as faculty senate president? Those are the kinds of people that, as a use case, others will trust.”

When these individuals are equipped to guide conversations about AI, they can influence adoption in ways central administrators cannot.

Consider the AI Learning Academy at the University of Florida, a peer-taught, intensive, multi-day professional development program designed to give faculty both **conceptual grounding and practical tools** to integrate AI into their teaching. The program combines fundamentals, ethics, and applied use cases, and is structured to help participants quickly move from exposure to implementation.¹³



Similarly, the University of Virginia now runs a Faculty AI Guides program, which designates faculty peers as on-the-ground advisors for generative AI in teaching. Rather than relying on a central office to provide all expertise, the program distributes knowledge across departments, creating a network of faculty who can translate AI into their own disciplinary contexts. This approach recognizes that adoption depends on trusted, local guidance—not just access to information.¹⁴

Auburn University has built a comprehensive, eight-module asynchronous course, *Teaching With AI @ Auburn*, through its Biggio Center for the Enhancement of Teaching and Learning. Each module allows faculty to engage on their own time and at their own level of readiness, an intentional design choice for what Auburn sees as a transformational shift. The course walks faculty through not just the tools, but the questions they need to answer: how AI affects their courses, how students are using it, how assignments need to change, and what conversations need to happen within their disciplines.

What distinguishes Auburn’s approach is its depth and accessibility. It provides a structured pathway for participants—beyond a single workshop. About a quarter of Auburn’s faculty have already enrolled, suggesting that when training is flexible, relevant, and grounded in real teaching decisions, faculty will engage. As Asim Ali, executive director of the Biggio Center, pointed out, a transformational toolset “can’t be the firehose, come and get all the information at once.”¹⁵

All of these efforts reflect a critical insight: change spreads through people, not top-down policies and initiatives. Ultimately, teaching the trainers is not just about developing technical skills. It is about building confidence, reducing uncertainty, and creating a shared understanding of effective practice. Watson suggests starting with a staged approach, focusing on faculty teaching introductory or capstone courses before moving deeper into the disciplines.

Institutions that get this right will not be those that move fastest on AI, but those that move most deliberately in aligning people, practice, and purpose.

The Last Word

Generative AI is often viewed as a technological turning point for higher education. But the deeper challenge is cultural. Colleges and universities are figuring out how faculty work, how students learn, and how trust is sustained in an environment where the boundaries between human and machine-generated work are increasingly blurred.

That is why adoption must begin with culture. Higher education has long been difficult to change because authority is distributed, norms are local, and faculty autonomy is central to the enterprise. The very structures that slow change are also part of what gives academic work its legitimacy. AI strategy for faculty, then, cannot be imposed from above. It has to be built through the people closest to teaching and learning.

The ACT framework is one way to do that. Assessing reality grounds strategy in what is happening in practice. Curating and amplifying what works turns isolated experiments into shared learning. Teaching the people who shape practice builds the internal capacity for change to spread.

AI will not determine the future of higher education on its own. Whether institutions use this moment to strengthen or weaken the human core of teaching and learning is a choice they can make.



Endnotes

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Jeffrey Selingo is a higher education author and strategist who has written three New York Times bestselling books. His book *Who Gets In & Why: A Year Inside College Admissions*, published in 2020, was named among the 100 Notable Books of the year by The New York Times. His latest book, *Dream School: Finding the College That's Right for You*, is based on two-plus years of research and an original survey of 3,000 parents. A regular contributor to The Atlantic and The New York Times, Jeff is a special advisor for innovation and professor of practice at Arizona State University. He also co-hosts the podcast Future U. and writes a regular newsletter called Next. You can find out more about him at jeffselingo.com.

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